Although it could be speculated that Honecker had a vested interest in Apel's demise given his growing influence and proximity to Ulbricht, his explanation about the death was self-serving. He deflected blame away from where it belonged – SED hardliners, by insisting the New Economic System had not proved itself.3 'Apel failed in practice in the working out of a seven-year plan,' he asserted. 'He did not manage to perform the task as formulated.'4

One of his pet theories was that Apel's death may have stemmed from his personal life, but did not elaborate, 'the fact that he committed suicide has never been cleared up to this day'.5 Remarkably, Günter Mittag, co-inventor of the NES, continued his career and became a full member of the Politburo in September 1966, and remained a key figure in the GDR economy. In fact, he was one of the few men – perhaps the only man – that Honecker could call a true confidant.

The story of Apel's reforms is frustrating for what might have been. Some economists contend that, given a chance, the NES would have led to a flourishing economy by the 1970s.

True to form, the morning after Apel's suicide, all GDR media brimmed with condolences. A three-paragraph announcement in Neue Zeit claimed the economist had been suffering from circulatory ailments and suffered signs of 'nervous overload' which, despite all medical efforts, led to a sudden breakdown. 'Comrade Dr Erich Apel,' it added, 'suddenly and unexpectedly left us at the age of 48. His tragic death ends his fruitful and creative work. Comrade Apel made particularly great contributions to the planning and management of the GDR's economy.'6 Never one to play on the keyboard of a guilty conscience, the warmest praise came from Willi Stoph who spoke admiringly of Apel at his state funeral, saying his 'determined and conscientious work' won the respect and trust of Soviet comrades, 'his demise has left a painful void in our ranks'.7

And yet, at this grim time, a meeting of the eleventh Session of the Central Committee from 15 to 18 December 1965 finally put Ulbricht's New Economic System on a dead-end path. Once Apel's successor Gerhard Schürer was named, Honecker put down a marker against economists who had yet to 'overcome their tendency to adopt Western standards', before